

Oilseeds of 1986 that made India self-reliant in edible oils, suggests wholesome changes.

“The solution lies in changing cropping policies and practices. Crop areas under pulses and edible oils need to expand and chemical fertilisers use gradually replaced with organic manures. Pulses don’t need urea, instead release nitrogen to soil; edible oils need less urea and DAP, and make phosphorous available to soil. These crops consume relatively less water and organic manures improve soil’s water retention capacity,” he says.

“Further, the food and fertiliser subsidies should be re-purposed to push for these changes and also guarantee full procurements,” Ramanjaneyulu says, adding that “only policy can create the drivers for the changes, reducing import dependence, saving forex and raising farmers income in the process.”

HALF-HEARTED EFFORTS

India launched two ‘atmanirbharta’ missions for edible oils in 2024 and pulses in 2025, incorporating the key strategies the NITI Aayog listed. Although these are early days, agricultural experts are not very enthusiastic.

One expert describes these missions as “technical revivals” which require clear implementation road-maps and close monitoring to succeed, another calls “non-serious.”

Ramanjaneyulu questions the Central government’s claims of a dramatic rise in their procurements—up by 5,359% from “1.52 lakh tonnes during 2009–14 to 82.98 lakh tonnes during 2020–25” in pulses and “more than 1,500% in the last 11 year” in oilseeds—stating that “the rise is due to poor base” and “the total procurement is too little.”

Official data show that India imported ₹1.7 lakh crore worth ed-

ible oils and pulses worth ₹31,794 crore in FY26, while the Centre’s approval for their procurement for the 2025–26 Kharif and Rabi seasons totalled ₹40,684 crore.

The PM-AASHA scheme of 2018 launched to give price support for these crops through procurements and deficit payments, spent only ₹6,941 crore in FY26 (RE) and has a budget of ₹7,200 crore for FY27 (BE). An investigative report of 2024 had shown that the real spending under this scheme was seen only around the 2019 and 2024 general elections; none in the intervening years.

heavily subsidised and widely distributed, accounting for 60% of total fertiliser use, despite causing nutrient imbalance and contaminating soil, water and air. The Nutrient-Based Subsidy (NBS) scheme of 2010, which promotes non-nitrogenous phosphatic (P) and potassic (K) fertilisers, has failed to make a dent as these are decontrolled and costlier. The nano fertiliser strategy, launched in 2021 to cut down imports, has also come a cropper.

Ritika Juneja, Senior Fellow at ICRIER, says the choices for India are to de-risk imports and reduce

FOR LONG, EXPERTS HAVE SUGGESTED THAT INDIA SHOULD PROCURE AND SUPPLY EDIBLE OILS AND PULSES THROUGH THE PDS TO ENSURE SELF-RELIANCE

For long, experts have suggested that instead of relying on markets, India needs to create an ecosystem for procuring and supplying edible oils and pulses through the public distribution system, like wheat and rice, to ensure self-reliance.

ENSURING FERTILISER SECURITY

Fertiliser shortages are chronic. From less than 1 million tonnes before mid-1960s, fertiliser imports shot up to 17.6 million tonnes in FY25. The Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (ICRIER) estimates the import dependency at 68.6% of the total fertiliser value chain in FY25 (44.5% feedstocks and 24.1% finished fertilisers).

Urea (N) remains controlled,

demand. In addition to diversifying import sources and ramping up domestic production, she insists on two key changes. First, shift from price-based subsidy to the fertiliser industry to direct cash transfers to farmers, based on area, cropping pattern and irrigation or expanding the NBS to include urea to correct price distortions across fertilisers or restricting quantity of fertilisers supplied to farmers. Second, diversifying to alternatives like ammonium sulphate, Triple Super Phosphate (TSP), Single Super Phosphate (SSP), nano, bio- and speciality fertilisers.

The task is cut out. Given the vulnerability to geopolitical disruptions, India must abjure import dependence with a single-minded pursuit. **BT**